

AIEC Global — Study Abroad Visa & Policy FAQ

Covers Australia, USA, Canada, UK, Japan, and South Korea only — AIEC Global's current focus countries. Compiled from official government immigration sources and reputable study-abroad portals. Figures such as fees, processing times, and proof-of-funds thresholds change periodically — treat specific numbers as current estimates and confirm with the relevant embassy/consulate or institution.

GENERAL

1. What is IELTS and how does the test work?

IELTS (International English Language Testing System) is a standardized English proficiency test used by universities, employers, and immigration authorities worldwide, with sections in Listening, Reading, Writing, and Speaking. It comes in Academic and General Training versions, is scored on a 0-9 band scale, and can be taken on paper or computer. IELTS scores are considered valid for two years from the test date. Test takers can retake IELTS an unlimited number of times with no mandatory waiting period, though full fees apply each time, and a newer "One Skill Retake" option lets test-takers redo just one section on the computer-delivered version.

(https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/International_English_Language_Testing_System)

2. What is PTE Academic and how does it differ from IELTS?

PTE (Pearson Test of English) Academic is a fully computer-delivered English proficiency test taken in a single 2-hour sitting, combining Speaking, Writing, Reading, and Listening into integrated tasks rather than separate sections, with responses scored by an automated AI system rather than a human examiner. It's scored 10-90 overall (not IELTS's 0-9 band scale) and results are typically available faster than IELTS, often within 1-2 days. PTE scores are valid for 2 years from the test date (3 years specifically for Australian permanent residency purposes), and candidates can retake it as many times as they want, with a minimum 5-day gap between bookings and up to 12 attempts allowed in any 12-month period — you also choose which attempt's score to send to an institution, so a weaker retake doesn't overwrite a stronger earlier score.

(<https://www.upgrad.com/study-abroad/exam/pte/exam-pattern/>)

(<https://www.testprepistanbul.com/en/blog/understanding-pte-academic-retake-rules-score-release>)

3. What is TOEFL and how is it different in format and retake rules?

TOEFL iBT (Test of English as a Foreign Language) is another widely accepted English proficiency test, delivered entirely online and testing Reading, Listening, Speaking, and Writing skills, commonly required by universities, especially in the US and Canada. TOEFL scores are also valid for two years from the test date, after which the score is permanently removed from the testing agency's database and cannot be reinstated. Unlike IELTS, TOEFL cannot be retaken section-by-section — the full exam must be redone each time — and the mandatory waiting period between attempts is short (a few days). (<https://www.geeksforgeeks.org/toefl/toefl-score-validity/>)

4. What's the difference between a Diploma, Bachelor's, Master's, and PhD?

A diploma is a shorter, practically-focused credential usually lasting one to two years and aimed at job-ready skills rather than deep theoretical study. A bachelor's degree is an undergraduate

qualification generally taking three to four years, offering broad academic grounding in a subject along with critical thinking and research skills. A master's degree is a postgraduate qualification pursued after a bachelor's, typically requiring one to two further years and involving more specialized, research-oriented study. A PhD/doctorate is the highest academic qualification, generally taking three to six years, centered on producing original research culminating in a dissertation. Exact durations vary by country and institution. (<https://www.mastersportal.com/articles/3385/diploma-vs-degree.html>)

5. What is a Statement of Purpose (SOP) and what should it include?

A Statement of Purpose (SOP), sometimes called a personal statement, is an essay submitted with a university application that explains why you want to study a particular course, your academic and professional background, and your future goals. A strong SOP generally has an introduction stating your objective, a body covering your academic/professional background and reasons for choosing the field and institution, and a conclusion tying your goals to what the program offers. Exact format, length, and required content vary by university and country, so applicants should always check specific program guidelines. (<https://www.idp.com/india/study-abroad/statement-of-purpose/>)

6. What is a Letter of Recommendation (LOR) and who should write it?

A Letter of Recommendation (LOR) is a reference letter, usually from a professor, employer, or academic supervisor, that vouches for an applicant's academic ability, character, and potential to succeed in a program abroad. There are generally two types — academic LORs, written by teachers, professors, or academic mentors, and professional LORs, written by employers or supervisors — and most universities ask for one or more of either type depending on the level and type of program. The best recommender is someone who knows the applicant well enough to speak specifically and credibly about their skills and readiness for study abroad, rather than someone with just a senior title. (<https://www.aeccglobal.com/applications/letter-of-recommendations>)

7. What is an education loan for studying abroad and how does it generally work?

An education loan for studying abroad is financing taken from a bank or lender to cover tuition and living costs, typically repaid after a moratorium period that usually extends through the course plus a grace period. Loans are broadly split into "collateral" (secured) loans, which require pledging an asset like property or a fixed deposit as security, and "non-collateral" (unsecured) loans, where approval instead depends on factors like the university, course, academic profile, and a co-applicant's financial standing. The general process involves securing a university offer, choosing a lender, submitting academic and financial documents, getting the loan sanctioned, and having funds disbursed directly to the university or the student, though specific terms vary widely by lender and country. (<https://www.credila.com/article/non-collateral-education-loan-for-abroad>)

8. What is a gap year/study gap and how do universities generally view it?

A gap year (or "study gap") refers to a break, often one year or more, between completing one level of education and starting the next, sometimes used for work, travel, or personal development. Most universities are generally open to gap years and some, including several in the US and UK, actively encourage or even fund them, viewing a well-explained gap as a sign of maturity and purpose rather than a red flag. That said, how a longer or unexplained gap is perceived can vary significantly by country and institution, so applicants are usually advised to be able to explain the gap clearly in their SOP or application.

(<https://www.theuniguide.co.uk/advice/ucas-application/how-do-universities-view-gap-years>)

9. What's the general difference between using an education agent/consultancy versus applying directly to universities?

An education agent or consultancy offers guidance on choosing universities and courses, help with application forms, essays, and documentation, and support navigating visa and financial requirements. A key distinction: agents are often paid a commission by partner universities for enrolling students (so their recommendations may be limited to those partner schools), while independent consultants are typically paid by the student/family and can advise more broadly. There's no requirement to use an agent — students can apply directly to almost any university abroad, and doing so is a perfectly valid option, though it means doing more research and paperwork independently. (<https://www.usnews.com/education/best-colleges/articles/pros-cons-of-using-international-student-agents-consultants>)

10. What is a Statement of Financial Support / Affidavit of Support?

A Statement of Financial Support (or affidavit of support) is a signed document, usually from a parent, relative, or sponsor, formally declaring that they have sufficient funds to cover a student's tuition, accommodation, and living expenses abroad. It is generally required at two points: during university admission and during the student visa application, to reassure authorities the student won't become a financial burden. It's typically backed by supporting documents such as bank statements, income proof, and evidence of the sponsor's relationship to the student, though exact requirements differ by country and institution. (<https://schoolconnect.com/blog/affidavit-of-support-for-study-abroad/>)

11. How far in advance should someone start planning to study abroad?

Advisors generally recommend starting the study-abroad planning process 12 to 18 months before the intended intake, to allow time for research, standardized test preparation, and university shortlisting. A common rough timeline: research and shortlisting 12-18 months out, test prep (IELTS/TOEFL etc.) around 10-12 months out, application preparation 6-8 months out, and final submission around 5-6 months before the intake begins. Recommendation letters should ideally be requested at least six months in advance.

(<https://www.applyboard.com/blog/timeline-for-international-students>)

12. What's the difference between a conditional and unconditional offer letter?

A conditional offer letter means a university has provisionally accepted a student but requires them to still meet certain conditions, most commonly a minimum final academic score or a required English test result, before admission is confirmed. An unconditional offer letter means the student has met all requirements and their place is fully guaranteed, with no further conditions to satisfy. Once a student meets the stated conditions on a conditional offer, the university converts it into an unconditional offer, which is often needed to proceed with loan applications, visa processing, and accommodation booking. (<https://www.idp.com/india/study-abroad/types-of-offer-letters/>)

13. What is a "confirmation of enrollment" type document (like the US I-20 or UK CAS) generally used for?

Many countries require an official document issued by the university confirming a student's enrollment, program details, and evidence of sufficient funding, before a student visa can be applied for — in the US this is the Form I-20, and other countries have their own equivalents such as the UK's CAS (Confirmation of Acceptance for Studies). These documents typically include identifying details, the program of study, start/end dates, and estimated costs, and serve as the key document consulates use to verify a student's eligibility for a visa. They are also generally needed for re-entry

into the country if a student travels abroad during their studies. The specific name, format, and requirements of this document vary significantly by country. ([https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/I-20_\(form\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/I-20_(form)))

14. What is student health insurance for study abroad and why is it usually required?

Student health insurance is a policy that covers medical costs like doctor visits, hospitalization, emergency care, and sometimes medical evacuation while studying in a foreign country. Many countries make it a legal requirement for obtaining a student visa (common examples include the US, Australia, Germany, and New Zealand), and universities themselves often mandate it as a condition of enrollment. Since medical treatment is rarely free for international students and can be very expensive, insurance protects against unexpected high costs and ensures timely access to care; exact mandatory coverage levels and rules differ by country.

(<https://studee.com/guides/why-you-need-medical-insurance-when-you-study-abroad>)

15. What's the difference between an "intake" and a "semester"?

An "intake" refers to a specific enrollment period when a university accepts and processes new student applications for a given start date, most commonly Fall, Spring, or Summer. A "semester" refers to one academic term of study within the year (e.g., the Fall semester runs from around September to December). In practice the two terms are often used interchangeably in study-abroad contexts because each intake usually corresponds to the start of a semester, though Fall is typically the largest/primary intake with the widest course availability, while Spring and Summer intakes usually offer fewer programs. (<https://ymgrad.com/article/intakes-in-usa>)

16. What is a foundation/pathway program and when is it typically needed?

A foundation (or pathway) program is a preparatory course, usually lasting 8-12 months, that bridges the gap between a student's prior education and the entry requirements of a bachelor's or master's program abroad. It typically combines subject-specific academic preparation with English language training and, on completion, guarantees progression into the first year of a linked degree program rather than awarding a separate qualification itself. Students commonly need one if they come from an education system with fewer years of schooling than the destination country requires, don't yet meet the required English test score, or have grades slightly below direct-entry requirements. The difference between "foundation" and "pathway" is mostly administrative — a foundation programme is run directly by the university, while a pathway programme is run by a third-party partner institution. (<https://www.sableinternational.com/blog/what-is-a-foundation-programme-and-how-can-it-help-you-study-abroad>)

AUSTRALIA

17. What kind of student visa do I need to study in Australia?

You need the Subclass 500 Student Visa, Australia's single visa category covering all levels of study from ELICOS through higher education and research doctorates. To be eligible you must hold a valid Confirmation of Enrolment (CoE) from a registered course and meet financial, English language, and Genuine Student requirements. (<https://www.aecglobal.com/study-in-australia/visas/student>)

18. How long does the Australian student visa take to process?

Processing time depends heavily on your institution's priority status under the national planning cap: some Priority 1 providers see visas processed in as little as 7 days, while lower-priority applications can take around 10 weeks. As a general benchmark, about 50% of higher education student visa

applications are processed within 28 days and 90% within about 5 months. You can lodge your application up to 124 days before your course starts.

(<https://blog.migroto.com/2026/02/07/how-long-does-the-subclass-500-visa-take-to-process/>,
<https://www.solmigration.com/blog/student-visa-processing-time/>)

19. What documents do I need for the Australian student visa application?

Core documents include your Confirmation of Enrolment (CoE), passport, evidence of financial capacity, academic transcripts and certificates, English test results, health insurance (OSHC), and a Genuine Student statement. Financial evidence must show you can cover tuition, travel, and living costs for yourself and any accompanying family members.

(<https://www.aeccglobal.com/study-in-australia/visas/student>)

20. What English test scores are usually required for Australia?

Accepted tests include IELTS, TOEFL iBT, PTE Academic, and Cambridge C1 Advanced, with the specific minimum score depending on your course level and institution. Most universities require roughly IELTS 6.0-6.5 overall for undergraduate and postgraduate coursework programs, though this varies by provider and program.

(<https://www.nomadcredit.com/blog/student-visa-australia-latest-requirements-processing-time>)

21. Can I work while studying in Australia?

Yes, most Subclass 500 holders can work up to 48 hours per fortnight (about 24 hours per week) while their course is in session, with unlimited hours during official course breaks. Students enrolled in a Master's by Research or a Doctorate face no work-hour cap once their course begins. (<https://assist.applyboard.com/hc/en-us/articles/6478399259789-Working-While-Studying-in-Australia-Hours-Minimum-Wage-Rights-for-International-Students-2026>)

22. Is there a post-study work option after graduating in Australia?

Yes, the Temporary Graduate visa (Subclass 485) lets eligible graduates stay and work in Australia after finishing their course, with unrestricted work rights. The Post-Higher Education Work stream grants 2 years for a bachelor's or master's-by-coursework degree, 3 years for a master's-by-research, and 4 years for a doctorate; most applicants must be under 35. Processing typically takes 3 to 6 months. (<https://www.tiltslms.com/blog/post-study-work-visa-australia-485>,
<https://thenextglobal.com/australia-post-study-work-visa/>)

23. Can my family come with me while I study in Australia?

Yes, your spouse or de facto partner and dependent children under 18 can be included in your visa, but all family members must be declared at the time you lodge your original Subclass 500 application. Partners of bachelor's-level students can work up to 48 hours per fortnight, while partners of master's or PhD students can work full-time. Overseas Student Health Cover (OSHC) must cover every accompanying family member. (<https://www.migrationguru.com.au/bringing-your-family-to-australia-on-a-student-visa/bringing-your-family-to-australia-on-a-student-visa-subclass-500-2026-guide/>)

24. What scholarships are available for international students in Australia?

The Australia Awards Scholarships, funded by the Australian Government (DFAT), cover full tuition, return airfare, a living allowance, and health cover, mainly for students from the Indo-Pacific region. Destination Australia offers up to AUD 15,000 per year for students studying at regional campuses, open to all international students. Many universities also offer their own merit-based scholarships. (<https://australiaawards.com.au/>,

<https://www.aeccglobal.com/scholarships/study-abroad-scholarship-in-australia>)

25. When do Australian universities have their intakes?

Australia has three main intakes: February (Semester 1, the largest with the most course and scholarship options), July (Semester 2), and a smaller November intake. Exact dates vary by university and program, with some institutions starting Semester 1 in March instead.

(<https://www.idp.com/blog/key-intake-dates-australia/>,
<https://gostudyin.com/study-in-australia/study-info/intakes/>)

26. How much does the Australian student visa cost and how much money do I need to show?

The Subclass 500 visa application fee is around AUD 2,500 for most applicants (concessional rates apply to some ELICOS/ASEAN and Pacific-region students). For proof of funds, the primary applicant must show living costs of AUD 29,710, plus AUD 10,394 for a spouse/partner and AUD 4,449 per dependent child, in addition to tuition and travel costs. (<https://www.visaverge.com/f1visa/australias-student-visa-subclass-500-fee-hits-record-aud-2000-highest-globally/>, <https://assist.applyboard.com/hc/en-us/articles/6478333801869-Australia-Student-Visa-Subclass-500-2026-Requirements-and-How-to-Apply>)

USA

27. What visa do I need to study in the USA and what's it called?

You need the F-1 Student Visa, issued to those enrolled in academic programs at SEVP-certified schools (a separate M-1 visa exists for vocational study). It requires an I-20 form issued by your school and registration in the SEVIS system before you can apply.

(<https://www.immi-usa.com/f-1-processing-time/>)

28. What's the F-1 visa application process and how long does it take?

The process involves receiving your I-20 from an SEVP-certified school, paying the SEVIS I-901 fee (\$350), completing the DS-160 online form, paying the \$185 visa fee, and attending an in-person interview at a US embassy or consulate. End-to-end, from receiving your I-20 to visa issuance, typically takes two to four months, though interview appointment availability varies a lot by country and season. (<https://manifestlaw.com/blog/how-long-does-it-take-to-get-an-f1-visa>, <https://www.amerigoeducation.com/news/f-1-visa-to-arrival-timeline-for-students-2026>)

29. What documents are needed for the F-1 visa interview?

You'll need your passport, DS-160 confirmation page, I-20, SEVIS fee receipt, and interview appointment confirmation, plus financial evidence such as bank statements, an Affidavit of Support, sponsor income documents, or scholarship letters. Financial proof should show liquid funds covering at least your first year's Cost of Attendance as listed on your I-20.

(<https://yocket.com/blog/step-by-step-guide-for-student-f1-visa-interview-process>,
<https://yocket.com/blog/showing-your-finances-i20-f1-visa-interview>)

30. What English test scores do US universities usually require?

Requirements vary widely by school: TOEFL scores commonly range from about 79-80 at most universities up to 100+ at highly competitive schools. For IELTS, most US universities accept scores between 6.0 and 6.5, while top-ranked universities may expect around 7.0. Many schools also accept the Duolingo English Test as an alternative.

(<https://study.com/resources/toefl-scores-us-universities-2025.html>,
<https://www.aeccglobal.co.th/en/blog/minimum-ielts-and-toefl-requirement-in-usa-universities>)

31. Can international students work in the USA while studying?

On-campus work is limited to 20 hours per week during the academic semester and full-time during official school breaks, and doesn't require separate authorization beyond reporting to your school's Designated School Official. Off-campus work related to your major is possible through Curricular Practical Training (CPT) after two semesters of full-time enrollment.

(<https://www.isoa.org/blog/can-you-work-while-studying-in-the-us-f-1-visa-employment-guide>,
<https://iss.wisc.edu/employment/cpt/>)

32. Is there a post-study work option in the USA?

Yes, Optional Practical Training (OPT) allows F-1 graduates to work in the US for 12 months in a job related to their field of study, without needing employer sponsorship. Graduates with STEM degrees can extend this by an additional 24 months (36 months total). Many graduates then transition to the H-1B specialty occupation visa, which has an annual cap of 85,000 and is allocated through a lottery. (<https://gradright.com/opt-in-usa-guide-2026-eligibility-duration-stem-extension-h-1b-pathway/>, <https://www.uscis.gov/working-in-the-united-states/students-and-exchange-visitors/optional-practical-training-extension-for-stem-students-stem-opt>)

33. Can my spouse or children come with me on an F-1 visa?

Yes, spouses and unmarried children under 21 can accompany you on F-2 dependent visas, but F-2 holders are not permitted to work under any circumstances. F-2 spouses can only study part-time (not full-time), and F-2 children can attend K-12 school full-time.

(<https://www.myvisasource.com/usa-immigration/f2-visa-us>,
<https://oia.osu.edu/international-students/immigration-information/f-2-and-j-2-dependents>)

34. What scholarships are commonly available for international students in the USA?

The Fulbright Foreign Student Program is a US government-funded, merit-based scholarship covering tuition, airfare, a living stipend, and health insurance for graduate study and research, awarding scholarships to roughly 4,000 international students annually. Many top universities also offer their own need-based or merit-based scholarships to international undergraduates, typically ranging from \$3,000 to \$30,000 per year. (<https://fulbrightprogram.org/>,
<https://www.scholars4dev.com/6499/scholarships-in-usa-for-international-students/>)

35. When do US universities have their intakes?

The Fall intake (starting late August/September) is the primary cycle, accounting for roughly 70-80% of international admissions, with Early Action/Decision deadlines around November 1 and Regular Decision deadlines typically January-February. Spring intake (starting January) is a smaller secondary cycle with deadlines usually around June-October of the prior year.

(<https://leapscholar.com/blog/fall-admissions-in-usa-deadline-intake/>,
<https://yocket.com/blog/application-deadlines-for-us-universities-spring-fall-summer-winter>)

36. What does the US student visa cost and how much money must I show?

The SEVIS I-901 fee is \$350 and the DS-160 visa application fee is \$185, plus school application fees which vary by institution. There's no single fixed "proof of funds" figure; you must show liquid funds sufficient to cover the first year's Cost of Attendance as stated on your I-20, which varies by school (often ranging from roughly \$25,000 to \$80,000+ per year).

(<https://www.immi-usa.com/f-1-processing-time/>,
<https://yocket.com/blog/showing-your-finances-i20-f1-visa-interview>)

CANADA

37. What visa do I need to study in Canada?

You need a Study Permit issued by Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada (IRCC), required for most programs longer than 6 months. It is not technically a "visa" but a permit, and you'll typically also need a visitor visa or eTA to enter Canada, usually issued alongside the study permit. (<https://www.canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/services/study-canada/study-permit/get-document-s/financial-support.html>)

38. How long does the Canada study permit take to process?

Processing time depends on your route: Student Direct Stream (SDS) applicants from eligible countries can get decisions in around 20 calendar days if the application is complete, while non-SDS applications generally take 8-16 weeks. Realistic overall processing for most applicants falls between 8 and 12 weeks. (<https://www.nomadcredit.com/blog/canadian-student-visa-processing-time>, <https://www.uscaacademy.com/blog/canada-study-permit-processing-times/>)

39. What documents are needed for a Canada study permit?

You need a Letter of Acceptance from a Designated Learning Institution (DLI), a valid passport, and proof of financial support covering tuition, living expenses, and travel. A Provincial Attestation Letter (PAL) is now mandatory for most applicants. Accepted proof-of-funds documents include a Guaranteed Investment Certificate (GIC), Canadian bank account statements, a confirmed education loan, four months of bank statements, or a sponsor letter. (<https://www.canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/services/study-canada/study-permit/get-documents/financial-support.html>, <https://assist.applyboard.com/hc/en-us/articles/40602028625933-Proof-of-Financial-Support-for-a-Canada-Study-Permit-2026-IRCC-Requirements>)

40. What English test scores do Canadian universities require?

There's no IELTS requirement set by IRCC itself for the study permit — that's determined by each institution. Most universities require roughly IELTS 6.0-6.5 overall (no band below 6.0) for undergraduate programs, and 6.5-7.0 overall for postgraduate programs. (<https://ieltskaro.com/ielts-minimum-score-for-canada-student-visa/>)

41. Can international students work while studying in Canada?

Yes, students can work up to 24 hours per week off-campus during regular academic sessions once they meet eligibility conditions (enrolled full-time in a program of 6+ months, studies started, valid SIN, and permit shows work authorization). On-campus work has no hour limit, and full-time off-campus work is allowed during scheduled breaks, capped at 180 days per calendar year. (<https://www.canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/services/study-canada/work/work-off-campus.html>, <https://mystudentrights.ca/learn/24-hour-work-limit-international-students>)

42. Is there a post-study work or PR pathway in Canada?

Yes, the Post-Graduation Work Permit (PGWP) lets eligible graduates work in Canada with an open work permit after completing their studies, and this Canadian work experience strengthens eligibility for permanent residence pathways, most notably the Canadian Experience Class (CEC) under

Express Entry (generally requiring 12 months / 1,560 hours of qualifying Canadian work).
(<https://immigrationnewscanada.ca/pgwp-to-pr-pathway-for-students-canada/>,
<https://www.canadim.com/news/new-2026-express-entry-pathways/>)

43. Can my family come to Canada while I study?

Dependent children under 22 can generally accompany you, and those of pre-school, primary, or secondary age can study without needing their own study permit. Since January 2025, a spouse or common-law partner can only get an open work permit if you're a full-time student in a master's program of 16+ months or a doctoral program. Family members should apply for their documents alongside your study permit application. (<https://www.cicnews.com/2025/11/open-study-permits-available-to-family-members-of-international-students-and-foreign-workers-1162805.html>, <https://internationalexperience.utoronto.ca/international-student-services/immigration/studying-in-canada/bring-your-dependants>)

44. What scholarships are available for international students in Canada?

The Lester B. Pearson International Scholarship at the University of Toronto is one of Canada's most prestigious awards, covering full tuition, books, fees, and residence costs for four years for about 37 incoming undergraduates a year. Many other Canadian universities also offer their own entrance and merit scholarships specifically for international students; specifics and deadlines vary by institution and by year. (<https://future.utoronto.ca/pearson-scholarships>, <https://internationalexperience.utoronto.ca/global-experiences/global-scholarships/lester-b-pearson-scholarship>)

45. When do Canadian universities have their intakes?

Canada's main intakes are September (Fall, the largest with the most scholarship and program options), January (Winter), and May (Summer, offered by fewer programs). Students are generally advised to start their application process 6-8 months before their intended intake.
(<https://accessedu.net/resource/canada-intakes>, <https://www.aecoverseas.com/blog/september-intake-in-canada-2026-universities-courses-and-deadlines/>)

46. What does the Canada study permit cost and how much money must I show?

The study permit application fee is CAD 150, plus a CAD 85 biometrics fee if applicable, in addition to separate university application fees (typically CAD 100-250 per institution). For proof of funds, figures cited recently range from about CAD 20,635 to CAD 23,448 per year for a single applicant's living costs, on top of first-year tuition and return travel costs. (<https://www.visavio.ca/immigration-post/blog.php?slug=canada-study-permit-fees-2026-complete-payment-guide>,
<https://officialrequirements.com/guides/canada-study-permit-proof-of-funds/>)

UK

47. What visa do I need to study in the UK?

You need a Student visa (previously called Tier 4), sponsored by a licensed UK education provider that issues you a Confirmation of Acceptance for Studies (CAS). The CAS is only valid for 6 months from the date it's issued, and you can apply for your visa up to six months before your course start date. (<https://tarve.co.uk/blog/uk-student-visa-processing-time-2026>,
<https://unilink.co/posts/uk-student-visa-2026-cas-financial-requirements-graduate-route/>)

48. How long does the UK student visa take to process?

Standard processing for applications made from outside the UK is about 3 weeks; if you're already in the UK and switching or extending onto a Student visa, standard processing takes about 8 weeks. Faster paid options exist: a Priority service (around £500) usually gives a decision within 5 working days. (<https://www.avanse.com/blog/uk-student-visa-processing-time-complete-guide-2026>, <https://www.globalpathways.co.uk/uk-student-visa-processing-time/>)

49. What documents are needed for a UK student visa?

You need a valid passport, your CAS reference number from your sponsoring institution, and financial evidence proving you can cover living costs (and any unpaid tuition) for up to 9 months. This money must be held in your own account, a parent/guardian's account, or via an approved loan/sponsor for at least 28 consecutive days without dropping below the required amount. (<https://www.westminster.ac.uk/international/visas-and-advice/visas/student-visa/financial-requirements-and-the-28-day-rule>, <https://avidservicehub.com/uk-student-visa-financial-requirements-complete-guide-to-maintenance-funds/>)

50. What English test scores do UK universities require?

For university admission, most institutions require around IELTS 6.0 overall (5.5 per band) for undergraduate courses and 6.5 overall (6.0 per band) for postgraduate courses, though this varies by university and course. Separately, for the Student visa itself, the required English level rose from CEFR B1 to CEFR B2 for new applicants from 8 January 2026. (<https://www.aecoverseas.com/blog/uk-september-intake-2026-timeline-requirements-best-universities/>, <https://www.aeccglobal.com/study-in-uk/visas/student>)

51. Can international students work while studying in the UK?

Students on degree-level courses at recognised higher education providers can generally work up to 20 hours per week during term time, while those on below-degree-level courses are usually limited to 10 hours per week. This is a strict weekly cap covering all jobs combined, and full-time work is normally allowed during official vacation periods. (<https://www.davidsonmorris.com/uk-student-visa-working-hours/>, <https://withrowan.co.uk/guides/student-visa-part-time-work>)

52. Is there a post-study work option in the UK?

Yes, the Graduate Route visa lets eligible graduates of UK degrees stay and work (or look for work) without needing a job offer or sponsor. It currently lasts 2 years for most bachelor's/master's graduates who apply on or before 31 December 2026 (reducing to 18 months from 1 January 2027) and 3 years for PhD graduates. (<https://immigrationbarrister.co.uk/graduate-immigration-route-for-post-study-work/>, <https://gostudyin.com/study-in-uk/study-guides/post-study-work-visa-benefits-international-students/>)

53. Can my family come to the UK while I study?

Since January 2024, only two groups of students can bring dependants: postgraduate research students (PhD, doctorate, MPhil, or a research-based master's) and government-sponsored students on courses longer than 6 months. Taught master's, undergraduate, and diploma students can no longer bring a partner or children. (<https://relocly.co.uk/blog/uk-student-visa-dependants-2026-who-can-bring-family>, <https://www.gov.uk/student-visa/family-members>)

54. What scholarships are available for international students in the UK?

Chevening Scholarships are a highly competitive, fully-funded UK government award covering tuition, living costs, and flights for any eligible master's degree. GREAT Scholarships, jointly funded by the UK Government and British Council, offer around 99 postgraduate awards across 36 UK universities. Commonwealth Scholarships support students from Commonwealth countries pursuing master's or PhD study. (<https://study-uk.britishcouncil.org/scholarships-funding/chevening-scholarships>, <https://study-uk.britishcouncil.org/scholarships-funding>)

55. When do UK universities have their intakes?

September is by far the largest UK intake, offering around 90% of courses, with a smaller January intake and a limited May intake for select programs. For the September intake, key undergraduate application deadlines are typically in mid-October (for competitive courses) and mid-January for general courses. (<https://www.aecoverseas.com/blog/uk-university-intakes-2026-complete-guide-for-international-students/>, <https://aspireglobalpathways.com/uk-september-2026-applications-deadlines/>)

56. What does the UK student visa cost and how much money must I show?

The Student visa application fee is around £558, plus the Immigration Health Surcharge of £776 per year of visa validity, paid upfront. For maintenance funds, you must show £1,529 per month (up to 9 months) if studying in London, or £1,171 per month if studying outside London, held for 28 consecutive days. (<https://www.atava.co.uk/uk-student-visa-fees-april-2026/>, <https://gmsimmigration.co.uk/blog/uk-student-visa-maintenance-funds-2026-amounts-and-rules/>)

JAPAN

57. What visa do I need to study in Japan and how is it different from other countries' visas?

You need a "College Student" (or equivalent Student) visa, but unlike many countries, you cannot apply for it directly — you first need a Certificate of Eligibility (CoE) issued by Japan's Immigration Services Agency, which your school applies for on your behalf, and only then do you apply for the visa itself. (<https://cotoinstitute.com/certificate-of-eligibility-student-coe-visa-japan/>)

58. What is the Japan student visa application process and how long does it take overall?

First, your school submits the Certificate of Eligibility (CoE) application on your behalf, which typically takes about 3 months to process. Once you receive the CoE, you submit it with your passport and visa application to a Japanese embassy/consulate, which usually takes about a week. Overall, the full process is generally 6 to 8 months. (<https://nihongo-center.com/application-guidance/>)

59. What documents do I need for the Japan student visa/CoE application?

Common requirements include a valid passport, academic transcripts and certificates, a completed application form, and proof that a financial sponsor can support at least one year of tuition and living expenses. The CoE itself, once issued, is required to apply for the visa. (<https://www.icla.ygu.ac.jp/en/admission-process/student-visa/>)

60. What Japanese or English language level do I need to study in Japan?

For Japanese-taught university programs, JLPT N2 is generally considered the practical minimum for undergraduate admission, with N1 often required or preferred for competitive or graduate programs. If you enroll in an English-taught degree program, Japanese proficiency is often not required, though requirements vary by school. (<https://nihongo-career.com/tips/2026/03/04/do-you-need-jlpt-to-study-i>)

n-japan-complete-guide-for-international-students/)

61. Can international students work part-time while studying in Japan?

Yes, but only after obtaining a separate work permission from immigration, since the student visa itself does not include work rights. Once permitted, students can work up to 28 hours per week during term and up to 8 hours per day during official school vacations.

(<https://study.gaijinpot.com/faq/what-if-i-work-more-than-28-hours-on-my-student-visa-in-japan/>)

62. What happens after graduation — can I stay and work in Japan?

Graduates can apply to change status to "Designated Activities (Continuing Job Hunting)," a job-hunting visa that gives roughly 6-12 months to find work before switching to a work visa. Most graduates who find jobs move to the "Engineer/Specialist in Humanities/International Services" visa, provided the job relates to their field of study. (<https://www.jpss.jp/en/life/job/3/>)

63. Can I bring my spouse or children while studying in Japan?

Yes, university and graduate school students (not language school students) can apply for a "Dependent" visa for their legal spouse and unmarried minor children. Dependents do not automatically have work rights — they must separately apply for permission to work part-time, capped at 28 hours per week. (<https://cotoacademy.com/dependent-visa-japan-guide/>)

64. What scholarships are available for studying in Japan?

The Japanese Government (MEXT/Monbukagakusho) Scholarship covers full tuition plus a monthly stipend of roughly ¥143,000-145,000 for research, undergraduate, and other student categories. JASSO also offers scholarships like the MEXT Honors Scholarship for Privately-Financed Students, generally for students already enrolled in Japan, worth around ¥48,000-¥80,000 per month. (https://www.jasso.go.jp/en/ryugaku/scholarship_j/index.html)

65. When do Japanese universities have their intakes?

The main intake is April (Spring), with applications typically due around September-November of the prior year. A growing number of universities also offer a September/Fall intake aimed at international students, with applications generally due around March-May.

(<https://www.mastersportal.com/articles/2886/how-to-apply-to-universities-in-japan.html>)

66. How much money do I need to show for a Japan student visa?

You need to demonstrate that a financial sponsor can cover at least one year of tuition and living expenses; there isn't one fixed universal figure since amounts are assessed against the actual cost of your program and location. (<https://www.icla.ygu.ac.jp/en/admission-process/student-visa/>)

SOUTH KOREA

67. What visa do I need to study in South Korea?

Most international students studying a degree program need a D-2 (Student) visa; those attending Korean language institutes typically use a D-4 visa instead. The D-2 visa is tied to enrollment at an eligible South Korean university.

(<https://www.study-abroad.org/study-in-south-korea/visa-and-arrival/>)

68. What is the South Korea D-2 visa application process and how long does it take?

After being admitted and paying tuition, you receive a Certificate of Admission (COA) from your

university, then submit your application to the Korean embassy/consulate. Processing typically takes about 2-3 weeks after submission. After arriving in Korea, you must also register for an Alien Registration Card (ARC) within 90 days.

(<https://masonkorea.gmu.edu/international-students/student-visa/new-d-2-visa-application>)

69. What documents are needed for a Korea student visa?

Core documents include a valid passport, application form, passport photo, official Certificate of Admission/acceptance letter from the university, the school's certificate of business registration, and proof of financial capacity. The financial proof requirement is around KRW 20,000,000 (about USD 15,000), held for at least 28 days before applying.

(<https://www.haniseoul.com/blogs/korea-d2-d4-student-visa-guide>)

70. What language test scores are needed to study in South Korea?

For English-taught programs, universities typically ask for TOEFL iBT around 80+ or IELTS Academic around 6.0+. For Korean-taught programs, most universities require TOPIK Level 3 for undergraduate and TOPIK Level 4 for graduate admission.

(<https://qogentglobal.com/study-in-south-korea/admissions/eligibility>)

71. Can international students work part-time in South Korea?

Yes, but a separate part-time work permit is required in addition to the D-2 visa, and students must generally have been in Korea over 6 months and maintain a GPA of 2.0 or above. Undergraduates can typically work 10-25 hours per week and graduate/PhD students 15-30 hours per week during the semester. (<https://kowork.kr/en/blog/part-time-work-permit-guide-en>)

72. Is there a post-study work option after graduating in South Korea?

Yes, the D-10 Job Seeker visa lets graduates stay to look for professional-level employment, generally for up to 6 months at a time (extendable). Once a graduate secures a qualifying job, their employer sponsors a switch to the E-7 (professional) work visa.

(<https://www.jobploy.kr/en/content/d10-job-seeker-visa-guide-2026>)

73. Can I bring family members while studying in South Korea?

Yes, the F-3 dependent visa is available for the spouse and unmarried minor children of a D-2 visa holder, requiring proof of financial support and legalized family relationship documents.

(<https://www.haniseoul.com/blogs/south-korea-f3-dependent-visa-guide>)

74. What scholarships are available for studying in South Korea?

The flagship option is the Global Korea Scholarship (formerly KGSP), funded by the Ministry of Education, covering round-trip airfare, a settlement allowance, monthly stipend, full tuition, Korean language training, and medical insurance for undergraduate and graduate study.

(<https://gksscholarship.com/>)

75. When do South Korean universities have their intakes?

South Korea's academic year has two main intakes: Spring (March), the larger intake with more programs and scholarships, and Fall (September). Application windows vary by school but generally run several months ahead. (<https://qogentglobal.com/study-in-south-korea/explore/intakes-timelines>)

76. What financial proof amount is commonly required for the Korea student visa?

A commonly cited figure is around KRW 20,000,000 (roughly USD 15,000), which must usually be

held in the applicant's or sponsor's account for at least 28 days before the visa application. Exact amounts can vary by consulate and visa type.

(<https://www.haniseoul.com/blogs/korea-d2-d4-student-visa-guide>)